AMBER SHI 2025

HEARING CALIFORNIA





INTRODUCTION

Growing up in California, I have always been drawn to nature. The blue skies, mild weather, and wildlife give the state its distinctive character.

Hearing California is an original composition inspired by the sounds and sights of California. The project connects the state's natural life with musical interpretation by pairing MIDI music composed in Ableton Live with visuals of California's wildlife created in Max/Jitter.



VISUAL BACKGROUND

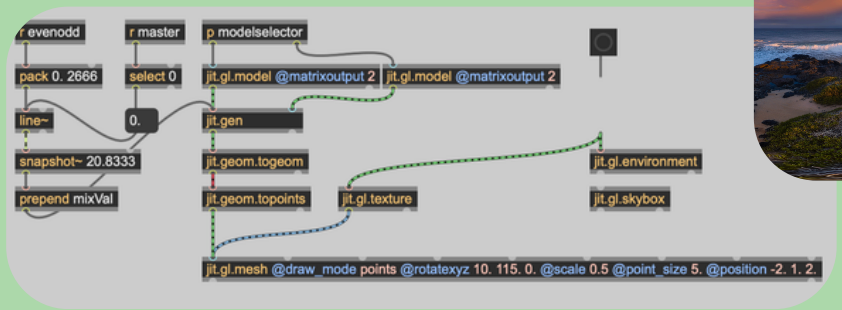
I developed 3D visuals in Max/Jitter to create a visual background that complements the music.

The main background is a 360° AI generated panoramic image of the California coastline, with small animals appearing as the focus of certain scenes.

I used jit.gl.model to load 3D models of animals and jit.gen to manipulate their geometry, creating transitions by morphing between different forms. I also rendered the geometry as point clouds, which produced a pulsing effect in the animals' shadows and silhouettes.

I also used jit.gl.multiple and jit.gl.gridshape to generate many instances of 3D spheres, creating bubble-like visuals. I then programmed smooth camera rotations using interpolation to add movement and changing angles to each scene.

Finally, I added a sequencer to sync the visual movements to the tempo of the music.





MUSIC & COMPOSITION

Composed entirely with MIDI instruments in Ableton Live, the piece has three sections: A1–B1 - B2–A2.

Part A1 opens with a four-note motif that forms the foundation of the main melody. The melody is carried by the upper register of the grand piano and sustained violin, while the piano's lower register, short viola, and short cello provide the accompaniment. Near the end of A1, two pads enter: Mindfulness creates a delicate shimmer like stars in the evening sky, and Still Sky evokes a shooting star streaking across it.

Part B1 develops the original motif with more scale-like phrases. A flute joins to carry the melody, and sustained viola, cello, and bass replace the short strings in the accompaniment. Two new pads are introduced: Downstairs suggests light wind and breeze, and Bells Mellow evokes dew droplets gently falling to the ground.

Part B2 strengthens the motif by adding more interval jumping. The short string accompaniments come back while a hybrid bass enters to highlight the tonic and add a sense of homecoming.

Part A2 returns with the original four-note motif. As the piece ends, the tempo slows, and the main melody trails off first while the string accompaniment continues until the music stops.

